

Feud with Trump has Ukraine on knife’s edge

Zelensky works to mend fences with his war-torn country’s strongest ally

BY ROBYN DIXON, SIOBHÁN O’GRADY, MARY ILYUSHINA AND CATHERINE BELTON

To save his country, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky hopes to salvage his relationship with President Donald Trump after it blew up very publicly this past week, Ukrainian lawmakers and experts say.

In three years of war, Ukraine has seen tens of thousands killed, millions displaced, cities destroyed and large swaths of land seized by Russia. But now Zelensky is grappling with a U.S. president who blames him for the war and seeks half of Ukraine’s mineral wealth in exchange for further support.

The feud may be Zelensky’s most consequential challenge since his decision to stay and fight after Russia invaded in February 2022. In Trump, he must deal with a thin-skinned ally known for nursing grudges — complicating Kyiv’s struggle to secure a peace deal that doesn’t compromise its security, sovereignty or economic capacity to rebuild, even as Russian President Vladimir Putin’s appetite to crush Ukraine’s autonomy remains undiminished.

Trump’s momentous foreign policy shift toward Russia, with talk of a peace deal that appears to give Putin much of what he wants, has alarmed Ukraine and its other Western allies. His attack on a U.S. ally defending itself against an invasion was unprecedented in modern U.S. diplomacy and threatens to upend decades of bipartisan alignment with Europe to counter Russia.

Trump’s description of Zelensky as a “dictator” who “started” the war and his avoidance of

SEE UKRAINE ON A14

Russian blame: U.N. resolutions from the U.S. and Kyiv differ. **A15**

Israel delays prisoner release as Hamas frees six hostages

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS, LIOR SOROKA, VICTORIA BISSET AND NIHA MASIH

Hamas freed six more Israeli hostages in Gaza on Saturday, but Israel said it would further delay the release of about 600 Palestinian prisoners and detainees over what it said were violations by Hamas, including handover ceremonies that it said humiliated hostages. The decision is likely to heighten tensions amid a fragile ceasefire agreement that began last month.

“In light of Hamas’s repeated violations, including the ceremonies that humiliate our hostages and the cynical exploitation of our hostages for propaganda purposes, it has been decided to delay the release of terrorists that was planned for yesterday until the release of the next hostages has been assured, and without the humiliating ceremonies,” Israeli

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In Lebanon: Hezbollah in financial vise as Iran supply lines dry up. **A16**

Ominous forces are converging in Africa.

The stakes are high, and the reverberations could be felt well beyond its borders.



AFRICA’S BELT OF TURMOIL

Across the breadth of Africa, Islamist extremism is increasing, military juntas spreading and Russian influence rising. Read more about the forces roiling this region and meet six individuals who have helped shape this new chapter of African history.

SPECIAL SECTION INSIDE

Proud Boys strut back into a different Washington

BY ELLIE SILVERMAN

Standing before the very building at the center of a riotous attack four years earlier that sent many of them to prison, Enrique “Henry” Tarrío of the Proud Boys called out to the small group of Jan. 6 defendants gathered beside him:

“Whose house?” Tarrío asked, turning toward the U.S. Capitol. “Our house!” they bellowed.

The event, an opportunity for Tarrío and other far-right leaders to amplify their telling of the attack, reflected a stunning reversal of fortunes for nearly 1,600 Capitol riot defendants and far-right leaders granted clemency. The men once firmly seen as fringe figures felt vindicated —

Once-jailed far-right group members ‘defiant’ as they arrive for CPAC

even celebrated — in the city that once jailed and prosecuted them.

As Trump has sought to recast the official public narrative about one of the most divisive chapters of recent U.S. history, some of those involved have benefited from their elevated profiles, converting the embrace of his MAGA base into public appearances and podcast interviews while openly mulling government jobs or running for elected office.

In recent days, Tarrío and other far-right leaders who call themselves “J6ers” tested that capital at the sprawling annual Conservative Political Action Conference at National Harbor in Maryland.

“The Boys are back in town,” Tarrío, who was convicted of seditious conspiracy, posted to X, alongside a photo of him with three of his co-defendants. “The Seditious 5 rides again!”

“It feels defiant,” Tarrío said, in an interview, about returning to Washington. “Those three years that were taken from me unjustly were so f---ing worth it. The size of the bullhorn that was given to me is ... huge.”

At first, Tarrío said security declined to permit him and oth-

ers entrance — a charge that prompted online backlash against event organizers. CPAC officials quickly issued a statement insisting they were welcome.

“In fact, CPAC has been a constant supporter of this persecuted community and we support wholeheartedly President Trump’s pardons of the J6 victims,” the organization stated on X.

That message, extremism researchers said, underscores why Tarrío, Oath Keepers founder Stewart Rhodes and others among the far right feel emboldened to push their agenda. As the conservative movement embraces them, experts fear political

SEE PROUD BOYS ON A6

Pentagon cull sends U.S. into unknown

CRITICS ALARMED BY UPENDING OF NORMS

Trump purges top brass, elevates an underling

BY DAN LAMOTHE AND MISSY RYAN

President Donald Trump’s Friday night purge of the Pentagon’s top officer and five other senior officials has thrust the institution into uncharted territory, with a retired general plucked from obscurity to serve as the commander in chief’s next senior military adviser and growing alarm among Trump’s critics about the encroachment of political warfare on an organization bound by the Constitution to remain nonpartisan.

The firings of Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Gen. Charles Q. Brown Jr. and Chief of Naval Operations Adm. Lisa Franchetti had been anticipated for months, after Trump and his supporters frequently accused them and other officials of putting “woke” diversity policies over the military’s primal responsibility to fight and win wars.

Still, their abrupt ousters — and those of the Air Force’s vice chairman, and the top military lawyers for the Army, Navy and Air Force — angered retired generals, lawmakers and experts on civil-military relations, even as they acknowledged that a president has the right to assemble a team of military leaders of his choosing and in whom he has total confidence.

Retired Gen. Martin E. Dempsey, a Joint Chiefs chairman under President Barack Obama, wrote online that such trust “should be based on their leadership, their integrity, their performance, the quality of their ad-

SEE PENTAGON ON A6

The Sunday Take: Trump always wanted to be king of the hill. **A2**

Musk demand: Fed staffers must detail week’s work or lose jobs. **A5**

Democratic AGs aim to block Trump’s policy romp

BY MAEVE RESTON, REIS THEBAULT, JOANNA SLATER AND SHAYNA JACOBS

LOS ANGELES — The directive was sweeping and unprecedented: Early in the evening of Jan. 27, the White House Office of Management and Budget ordered a temporary freeze on trillions of dollars in federal funding.

As chaos and panic erupted across the government, Democratic attorneys general from more than 20 states convened a staff call. The White House move was unlawful, they decided.

Lawyers from six states — New York, New Jersey, Massachusetts, Rhode Island, Illinois and California — worked through the night to draft a complaint. By the next day, they had filed the 44-page document in federal court, one of two lawsuits that within days had blocked the administration’s move temporarily.

The scope of the White House memo was “what made it so scary,” said Matthew Platkin, New Jer-

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The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54136
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